Doug Black

Writer and Creative Director · Brand Voice, Campaigns, Editorial, and Content Design

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I write campaigns, lead copy teams, and build the brand voices that underlie both. I've done it at agencies and in-house, often in categories where the subject is complicated and every line has to clear Legal and still sound like a person wrote it. I started as a journalist, and more recently, I train and evaluate AI models on writing quality as part of my practice.

RANGE

Brand voices built from nothing. SoundCloud hired me as the first dedicated writer in the company's history. AREA15 had no voice guide at all, which meant writing the rules while writing the site, forty-plus venues, each its own brand, and all required to sound like one place. Air Company and a stealth AI company were the same situation. Also Goldman Sachs Private Wealth, Verizon, Better.com, and Evercore. The test is whether somebody who is not a writer makes the right call with no writer in the room, which is also the test for a model.

Campaigns, platforms, and editorial programs. First writer on the Pepsi Refresh Project, which pulled Pepsi's Super Bowl budget and redirected it into public grants anyone could apply for. Five years on Lincoln across four vehicle launches and the brand's centennial. 100 Faces of Lincoln, a year-long platform where a hundred owners told their own stories: 52M impressions, 7.6% engagement, Silver Shorty Honor. At Four Seasons I built the editorial framework for a global content program across thirty-plus properties and dozens of languages, and reported the original stories that filled it. Brand film through to social: a branded documentary for Audi built around the Newport Folk Festival, plus the Lincoln centennial film.

Brand inside the product. A year embedded at Better.com writing the copy for one of the most anxiety-inducing processes in American life. At Goldman Sachs I led the language layer of the public design system, roughly 40 components across 60 pages. At Verizon, one vocabulary and one set of copy patterns across the site and the app, including dynamic headlines specified as patterns rather than lines. At Evercore, content design inside an investment bank's own product team.

AI, and how machines read what you publish. Training and evaluating models on writing quality means deciding, line by line, what separates fluent from good. It has made the brand voice guidelines I write stronger. It also means I know how models actually read, which is the live question behind generative and answer engine optimization. Most of that field is guessing; I work from the evidence.

EXPERIENCE

Creative Director, Copy — Lincoln Motor Company

Mar 2021 – May 2026

Hudson Rouge (WPP) · New York

Creative Director on Lincoln across campaign, launch, film, social, retail, OOH, CRM, and .com. Four vehicle launches and the brand's centennial. Owned the voice and the standards that held it across two offices, every agency partner, and every market. Mentored the writers working within it. Lincoln.com moved from 16th to 6th in J.D. Power's manufacturer website rankings between winter 2024 and winter 2025, and Lincoln finished 7th in Consumer Reports' 2026 Brand Report Card, the highest-ranked American brand and the biggest jump on the list.

Writer and Creative Director — Independent

2013 – Present

New York · Selected engagements

AREA15. Full-site voice and copy for a 35-acre immersive entertainment district in Las Vegas, forty-plus distinct venues that also had to feel like one place. Sole writer, thirty pages in ten weeks, reporting to the CMO and the VP of Creative. No voice guide existed, so I wrote the rules as I went and turned them into a reusable instruction set a model could run. Also Air Company (voice, identity, manifesto, tagline; Fast Company Top 10 Product Launches of 2019), Better.com, Evercore, AWS Wickr, Salesforce, Conductiv, Bloomberg, Mirror, Ergatta, Corro, Guy Harvey, rag & bone, Louis Vuitton, Mercedes-Benz, Audi, Artnet, Pantone, Bulleit, Buffy, Open Farm, Pantheon, and Mercor.

Senior Content Designer and UX Writer — Evercore

Mar 2025 – Feb 2026

Contract, through UX+ · Remote

Content design and UX writing for Evercore's application development team, working remotely inside the bank's own design and project systems under its access and compliance controls. A part-time ongoing engagement alongside agency work.

Copy Lead and Content Design — Goldman Sachs

Sep 2018 – Apr 2020

Publicis Sapient · New York

Embedded at Goldman Sachs headquarters. I wrote the brand voice guidelines for the Private Wealth Management platform and ran the copy team on the build, recruiting, onboarding, and managing junior writers. Led the language layer of the public design system, roughly 40 components across 60 pages, launched February 2020. Wrote the executive narrative that introduced an internal analytics platform to firm leadership, along with its technical documentation and its product language: three registers for one product, which is a reliable test of whether a voice system actually holds.

Lead Writer and Brand Voice — SoundCloud Go

Oct 2015 – Jul 2017

SoundCloud · New York

First dedicated writer in the company's history. No brand voice existed, so I wrote one, then launched SoundCloud Go, the first paid subscription, asking 175 million free users to start paying. The first structure drew real backlash. I read the complaints instead of defending the work, argued for the tiered version with a real free option, and wrote that too. It replaced the original and is still what SoundCloud runs. The voice became the company's voice and still is.

Senior Copywriter and UX Writer, Verizon Wireless — AKQA

Apr – Sep 2018

New York

Replaced years of conflicting conventions across VerizonWireless.com and the MyVerizon app with one vocabulary and one set of copy patterns governing navigation, product pages, onboarding, support, account management, and transactional messaging serving 113 million subscribers. Within seven months of launch, in-app bill payment moved from 68% to 85% and mobile sales conversion rose 15.6x. Webby Honoree.

Senior Copywriter and Content Design — MRM//McCann

Apr 2020 – Mar 2021

Client: Kashiyama the Smart Tailor · New York · Remote

Copywriting and content design for Kashiyama the Smart Tailor, a Japanese made-to-measure suiting brand entering the US market. Buying a custom suit online is a configuration flow rather than a product page, so the copy had to carry measurement, fabric, and fit for a customer who could not try anything on.

Senior Copywriter — Code and Theory

May 2014 – Apr 2015

New York

Media, financial, and services work across brand and product for Bloomberg, Comcast, and H&R Block.

Senior Copywriter — KBS

Oct 2013 – Apr 2014

kirshenbaum bond senecal + partners · New York

Brand and campaign copy for JBL, Harman Kardon, and Infiniti. Audio and automotive, where the product story is the whole pitch.

Copywriter → Senior Copywriter — Huge

Jul 2010 – Oct 2013

Brooklyn, New York

Pepsi Refresh and Four Seasons, above. The XL Insurance rebrand, including films I scripted and shot around interviews with the company's executives. Also Google, American Express, Barneys New York, Target, Sally Hansen, Optimum, and Pizza Hut.

Journalist, Contributing Editor, and Copywriter

2006 – 2010

New York Press · Cool Hunting · Big Spaceship · New York

Staff writer at New York Press, an alternative weekly, where I wrote the front of book and the police blotter and copyedited every issue, plus book and music reviews, interviews, and the occasional feature. Then contributing editor at Cool Hunting, covering design, technology, and culture. Freelance features for Wallpaper*, Surface and Zagat. First agency job at Big Spaceship on GE Healthymagination and Altoids. Clio Health, top interactive honor.

HOW I USE AI

I train AI models as part of my practice and write with them daily. Their range is superhuman and their scope is narrow. They are good at iterations, versions, and eliminating busywork. To write for an audience, though, the inputs have to be formalized and systematically noted, and the output can never ship without oversight and informed human judgment.

WHAT I DO

Brand Voice and Verbal Identity · Voice and Tone Guidelines · Campaign and Platform Concepting · Editorial Strategy and Programs · Content Design and UX Writing · Brand Film and Video · Naming · Team Leadership and Mentorship · Regulated and Trust-Sensitive Categories · SEO, GEO, and AEO · Model Training and Evaluation

EDUCATION AND AWARDS

University of Virginia · BA, History and Fiction Writing · Sketch and improv at UCB · Poetry at Gotham Writers

Cannes Lions · Clio Health, top interactive honor · International Design Awards, Gold · IxDA Best in Category · Webby Honoree · NYC Design Awards, Silver · Silver Shorty Honor · FWA, Mobile of the Day · Communication Arts · W3